

INQUIRIES IN SOCIOLOGY

Academic integrity principles

Sciences Po's educational project encourages students to develop **independent and critical thinking, intellectual honesty and respect for copyright and image rights** in the use of sources.

To help you meet these requirements and consolidate your learning, we invite you to refer to the following documents and resources:

[Academic rules and regulation \(article 12\)](#);

[Academic integrity charter](#);

[Mandatory academic integrity online training](#) on Moodle;

[Methodological resources](#) on the student website.

We remind you that any fraud or proven attempted fraud will be punished in accordance with the [disciplinary procedures](#) in force at Sciences Po.

Teacher: Quentin LACMARI

Year 2025/2026

Fall semester

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This seminar runs in parallel with the lecture course taught by Marta DOMÍNGUEZ FOLGUERAS. Building on the first-year *Introduction to Sociology* course, it aims to train students in empirical research methods and the practice of qualitative fieldwork.

Unlike the broad approach of the lecture course (which surveys the full range of sociological research methods), and given that quantitative and statistical methods are already covered in other courses, **this seminar will focus exclusively on qualitative data collection and interpretation.**

This course combines two complementary formats:

- **"How to" tutorial sessions**, that provide practical and theoretical guidance to support students' research projects and fieldwork. Each tutorial requires preparatory readings of assigned texts and active participation in discussions to apply concepts to individual research projects.
- **Workshop sessions**, that provide a collaborative space for students to present their research progress, receive peer and instructor feedback, and discuss fieldwork challenges, ethical considerations, and problem-solving approaches.

The course will be instructed in English, though readings and pedagogical material may also be in French.

Course Moodle Platform

All course materials – including texts, complementary resources, and assignments – will be centralized on the Moodle pages for: Inquiries in Sociology (202510 - 18342) or Inquiries in Sociology (202510 - 18343).

What you'll find on Moodle:

- Course Overview & Assignments: Detailed syllabus, grading criteria, and submission portals for written assignments.
- Weekly Resources: Required and supplementary readings, slides, and preparatory materials for each session.
- Research Project Hub: A dedicated space to submit working documents (proposals, field notes, drafts), request personalized feedback from the instructor and track your research progress collaboratively.
- Technical Toolkit: With guides and tutorials on Zotero (for bibliographic management), AI tools for research (ethical use cases) and documentary research methods (archives, databases, etc.).

Contact

You may contact me at any time at quentin.lacmari@sciencespo.fr for questions related to the course content, assessments, or your fieldwork commitments.

Please allow 48 hours for a response before sending a reminder.

I encourage you to ask questions during dedicated office hours, class breaks, or after lectures. These moments are ideal for personalized discussions.

For questions relevant to the entire class, please channel them through your student representative (*délégué*). This helps streamline communication, avoid redundancy, and ensure everyone benefits from the answers.

PEDAGOGICAL OBJECTIVES

This course adopts a practical, hands-on approach to sociological research, focusing on guiding students through the design and execution of a qualitative inquiry. Unlike more theoretical courses, it immerses students in the concrete challenges of empirical data production – from framing a research question to conducting fieldwork and disseminating findings. The dual aim is to **master qualitative methods** (interviews and

observations) and **engage with the theoretical and ethical stakes** of social science research, connecting to contemporary debates explored in other courses.

By the end of the semester, students will be able to:

- **Design and develop a research project**
- **Conduct empirical fieldwork**
- **Analyze and interpret qualitative data**
- **Produce a research report and communicate about your research process**

Active participation is expected, with students sharing their research interests, challenges, experiences, and insights throughout the course. While individual projects are permitted, **working in groups of up to 3 students** is highly encouraged to enrich perspectives and distribute workload.

Final group compositions and research topics must be submitted by the second session (September 16th) to ensure timely project development.

COURSE ASSESSMENT AND GRADE SYSTEM

This seminar is assessed on a **continuous evaluation basis** and accounts for 2/3rd of the final grade in the "Inquiries in Sociology" course. Students will be evaluated individually or in groups, based on the progress of their research project throughout the semester. Assessment will include:

- **A written research proposal, due to October 7th – 20%**

Per group, students will write a research proposal outlining research question and theoretical framework, your methodological approach and fieldwork plan, as well as a preliminary bibliography. The document must not exceed 2,000 words (±20%), including bibliography.

- **Oral presentations and participation to the workshop sessions – 20%**

Students will present their research progress during two key workshop sessions across the semester:

- **Session 6: Presentation of your research proposal** (October 14th)
- **Session 8: Presentation of your fieldwork progress** (November 4th)

These sessions assess students' ability to demonstrate active engagement with their research project, articulate clear arguments and maintain methodological coherence, respond thoughtfully

to peer and instructor questions and incorporate feedback to refine their work. Presentations should not last more than 10 minutes per group, to ensure a time for discussions and feedbacks.

- **An individual reflexive note, due to November 25th – 20%**

Individually, students will write a 2 pages document in which you must detail your personal contribution to the group's research, and reflect on the challenges encountered during your first fieldwork experience and how you addressed them.

- **A written research report, due to December 5th – 40%**

This final written assignment will take the form of a research report (maximum 20 pages, or 10,000 words $\pm 20\%$ - bibliography and appendices not included) submitted per group, synthesizing empirical findings and analysis, critical discussion linking data to theory and reflexive account of the research process and methodology. It will be composed of an abstract, an introduction, a literature review, your methodology and findings, followed by a discussion section and a conclusion.

The group report will receive a shared grade, while the individual note allows for differentiated assessment of each student's engagement and learning process.

Detailed methodological guidance – including specific evaluation criteria, grading rubrics, and examples of successful work – will be provided progressively throughout the semester during dedicated sessions.

DETAILED OUTLINE

(Changes may be made throughout the semester)

Session 1 – Introductive Presentation (September 9th)

Presentation, getting to know each other, discussing research themes and ways ahead

Session 2 – How to: Start a Literature Review and Think of a Research Question (September 16th)

Readings:

- GUSTAFSSON Karl et Linus HAGSTRÖM, « What is the point? Teaching graduate students how to construct political science research puzzles », *European Political Science*, vol. 17, n° 4, décembre 2018, p. 634-648.
- LEMIEUX Cyril, « Problématiser », in *L'enquête sociologique*, sans lieu, Presses Universitaires de France, rubrique « Sociologie », 2012, p. 27-51.
- MACHI Lawrence A. et Brenda T. McEVOY, « Introduction: Doing and Producing a Literature Review. An Overview », in *The literature review: six steps to success*, Fourth edition, Thousand Oaks, California, Corwin, 2022, p. 1-20.

Assignment: Submit groups and a preliminary topic proposal for your research project

Session 3 – How to: Develop your Research Design and Empirical Method (September 23rd)

Readings:

- FUJII Lee Ann, « Ethical challenges of micro-level fieldwork », Paper presented at the workshop on Field Research and Ethics in Post-Conflict Environments, 2008.
- HIBOU Béatrice, « Le terrain comme site cognitif. Une perspective webérienne de l'articulation empirie et théorie », *Sociologie*, vol. 12, n° 2021/4, 2021, p. 427-437.
- OLIVIER DE SARDAN Jean-Pierre, « The Policy of Fieldwork: Data Production in Anthropology and Qualitative Approaches », Antoinette Tidjani Alou (trad.), in *Epistemology, Fieldwork, and Anthropology*, New York, Palgrave Macmillan US, 2015, p. 21-63.

Session 4 – How to: Conduct Interviews (September 29th)

Readings:

- FUJII Lee Ann, « What is Relational Interviewing », in *Interviewing in Social Science Research: A Relational Approach*, 1^{re} éd., New York, Routledge, coll. « Routledge series on interpretive methods », 2018, p. 1-11.
- JOUNIN Nicolas, « Interroger : Accueillir l'exotisme », in *Voyage de classes : Des étudiants de Seine-Saint-Denis enquêtent dans les beaux quartiers*, Paris, la Découverte, coll. « La Découverte-poche », 2016, p. 115-174.
- QU Sandy Q. et John DUMAY, « The qualitative research interview », *Qualitative Research in Accounting & Management*, vol. 8, n° 3, 2011, p. 238-264.

Session 5 – How to: Conduct observations (October 3rd – make-up class)

Readings:

- FUJII Lee Ann, « Five stories of accidental ethnography: turning unplanned moments in the field into data », *Qualitative Research*, vol. 15, n° 4, 2015, p. 525-539.
- GEERTZ Clifford, « Thick Description: Toward an Interpretive Theory of Culture », in *The interpretation of Cultures: Selected Essays*, New York, Basic Books, 1973, p. 3-33.
- OLIVIER DE SARDAN Jean-Pierre, « Observation et description en socio-anthropologie », in Giorgio Blundo et Jean-Pierre Olivier de Sardan (éd.), *Pratiques de la description*, Paris, Éditions de l'École des hautes études en sciences sociales, coll. « Enquête », 2003, p. 13-39.

Session 6 – Workshop: Collective Writing (October 7th)

Workshop: Collective writing session and feedbacks on your research proposal progress.

Assignment: Return your research proposal (written) by 11:59 p.m.

Session 7 – Workshop: Student's Research Proposal (October 14th)

Assignment: Oral presentation and discussion of your research proposal

Session 8 – How to: Get Ready for Fieldwork! (October 21st)

Readings:

- **BOURDIEU Pierre**, « Participant Objectivation », *The Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute*, vol. 9, n° 2, [Wiley, Royal Anthropological Institute of Great Britain and Ireland], 2003, p. 281-294.
- EMERSON Robert M., Rachel I. FRETZ et Linda L. SHAW, « Fieldnotes in Ethnographic Research », dans *Writing Ethnographic Fieldnotes*, Second Edition, Chicago and London, The University of Chicago Press, 2011, p. 1-20.
- LEE-TREWEEK Geraldine et Stephanie LINKOGLE, « Putting Danger in the Frame », in *Danger in the Field*, London, Routledge, 2000, p. 1-19.

– Break –

Session 9 – Workshop: Student's Reflection on Fieldwork (November 4th)

Reading suggestions to guide you:

- BAJARD Flora, « Ceux que nous appelons "enquêtés" : construire, vivre et analyser le terrain comme tissu relationnel », dans *Journées d'études internationales - MIJMA La Migration Internationale des Jeunes et Mineurs Africains vers l'Europe*, Mohammedia, Morocco, 2023 (en ligne : <https://hal.science/hal-04081275>).
- FINE Gary Alan, « Ten Lies of Ethnography: Moral Dilemmas of Field Research », *Journal of Contemporary Ethnography*, vol. 22, n° 3, SAGE Publications Inc, 1^{er} octobre 1993, p. 267-294.
- GUILLEMIN Marilys et Lynn GILLAM, « Ethics, Reflexivity, and "Ethically Important Moments" in Research », *Qualitative Inquiry*, vol. 10, n° 2, 2004, p. 261-280.

Assignment: Oral presentation and discussion of your fieldwork advancement

– Public holiday on November 11th –

Session 10 – How to: Use Your Data (November 18th)

Readings:

- LAHIRE Bernard, « Précisions sur la manière sociologique de traiter du "sens" : quelques remarques concernant l'ethnométhodologie », *Langage et société*, n° 59, 1992, p. 73-89.
- OLIVIER DE SARDAN Jean-Pierre, « The Violence Done to Data: On a Few Figures of Overinterpretation », Antoinette Tidjani Alou (trad.), dans *Epistemology, Fieldwork, and Anthropology*, New York, Palgrave Macmillan US, 2015, p. 167-194.
- SCHWANDT Thomas A., Yvonna S. LINCOLN et Egon G. GUBA, « Judging interpretations: But is it rigorous? trustworthiness and authenticity in naturalistic evaluation », *New Directions for Evaluation*, vol. 2007, n° 114, 2007, p. 11-25.

Session 11 – How to: Present your Research Findings (November 25th)

Readings:

- BECKER Howard S., « Terrorized by the Literature », in Pamela Richards (éd.), *Writing for Social Scientists, Third Edition: How to Start and Finish Your Thesis, Book, or Article*, Chicago, London, University of Chicago Press, 2007, p. 135-149.

- CLIFFORD James, « Introduction: Partial Truths », dans George E. Marcus et James Clifford, *Writing culture: the poetics and politics of ethnography a school of American research advanced seminar*, Berkeley, University of California press, 1986, p. 1-16.
- LEMIEUX Cyril, « L'écriture sociologique », dans *L'enquête sociologique*, sans lieu, Presses Universitaires de France, rubrique « Sociologie », 2012, p. 377-402.

Assignment: Return your individual reflexive note (written) by 11:59 p.m.

Session 12 – Workshop: Collective Writing (December 2nd)

Workshop: Collective writing session and final feedbacks

Final Assignment: Write a research report is due to December 5th.

GENERAL READING SUGGESTIONS

- BEAUD Stéphane et Florence WEBER, *Guide de l'enquête de terrain : produire et analyser des données ethnographiques*, 4e éd. augmentée, Paris, la Découverte, coll. « Grands repères », 2010.
- BECKER Howard S., *Writing for Social Scientists: How to Start and Finish Your Thesis, Book, or Article*, Pamela Richards et a New Preface (éd.), Chicago, London, University of Chicago Press, 2007.
- EMERSON Robert M., Rachel I. FRETZ et Linda L. SHAW, *Writing Ethnographic Fieldnotes*, Second Edition, Chicago and London, University of Chicago Press, 2011.
- FUJII Lee Ann, *Interviewing in Social Science Research: A Relational Approach*, 1^{re} éd., New York, Routledge, coll. « Routledge series on interpretive methods », 2018.
- OLIVIER DE SARDAN Jean-Pierre, *Epistemology, Fieldwork, and Anthropology*, Antoinette Tidjani Alou (trad.), New York, Palgrave Macmillan US, 2015.
- *L'enquête sociologique*, Paris, Presses Universitaires de France, coll. « Quadrige » dirigée par Serge Paugam, 2012.